



Ubuntu One Files on iPhone

Ubuntu users rejoice as Canonical has released an app which enables Ubuntu users to access their files on the Ubuntu cloud <http://bit.ly/zYgtzU>

USB 3.0 on tablets and phones

USB 3.0 to get a slimmer form factor enabling adoption tablets and phones <http://bit.ly/y8da46>

How companies rip you off

When paying for one component and getting another “free” turns traumatic

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Samar bought a branded notebook with an extended three-year warranty. He was satisfied with it until it randomly started giving mild electric shocks during charging. One day, while working he dropped it due to such a shock, which resulted in a crack in the top layer of the front LCD and a dent around the keyboard. When the product was taken to the service centre, he was told that the electric shocks were due to the faulty earthing in old wirings of Indian homes. When Samar claimed warranty for repairs, he was denied benefits and instead told to pay almost half the price of a new device just for the broken glass.

It's not new to hear about companies charging exorbitant prices to replace spare parts. At times, these parts are not even essential, yet they're overpriced.

For example, in Samar's notebook it wasn't even the motherboard or main LCD itself but a plain glass covering for which the company had quoted the unrealistic price. The company justified its stand saying that it would change the entire LCD; but why should it? The consumer is being forced to pay for parts that are not even damaged.

Interestingly, Samar found out that the same company was only changing and charging for the glass panel in the American market. Why this discriminatory practice in the Indian market? Over-pricing of products and services without any reasonable basis amounts to “abuse of dominant position” which is actionable under the Competition Law. Complaints can be filed before the Competition Commission of India situated at New Delhi.

The company may directly and indirectly impose unfair and discriminatory conditions during the sale of products and services, which need to be identified. In fact, in certain situations there's no competition left and it virtually amounts to monopoly, prejudice to the interests of consumers. For example, a particular technology needed to repair or manufacture a product may only be available with a particular company. If its act limits your options, you can complain against it to the Competition Commission which in turn can initiate an inquiry under the provisions of the Competition Act. Acquainting yourself to companies' practices helps avoid being caught offguard. ■



We can help!

If you're facing a problem with your purchase, write to us at help@consumermate.com

COMPLAINTS RECEIVED

LAPTOPS

Service centre isn't responding to queries about my faulty laptop

I bought a Acer Aspire 4820TG whose fan module blade, I later found out, was broken. The service centre subsequently changed it. However, it isn't working properly even after replacing the motherboard and fan module. The service centre asked to call them in case of any problem, instead of calling customer care. But when they didn't respond or visit, I called CC and asked to speak to a senior person. After calling 3-4 times he said that he couldn't solve my problem and asked me to mail my issue at acer.cc@intarvo.com. After a bit of googling, I also left a mail at ailintouch@acer.co.in but no one responded.

Another thing is that the service centre uses cheap thermal paste. If we're getting cheap service from this service centre,

why should we prefer their service? I would have gone to some local shop and asked them use good thermal paste. At least I would know that I'm getting good quality service.

Now I'm awaiting a response. In case this doesn't work out, I plan to file a case in consumer court.

I've had enough of this mental torture and waste of time. I just want to get my whole money refunded because I simply don't want to be the customer of a company that doesn't have proper quality check or customer support. Please help me get a refund.

Contacted By: Vikas Sharma

Answer By Consumermate:

Dear Consumer,
It's good that you're aware of your consumer rights. Product replacement or money refund isn't easy in the first

instance unless the product is proved to be inherently defective. Please give them the product for repair once with strict instructions. Before you lodge a complaint, write a letter to them in the shape of a legal demand notice detailing all your problems. Mention all relevant details of earlier job sheets, if you have any. In case, they don't come up with a solution then you may go ahead with your complaint in the district consumer forum. There's a chance that the company would resolve the problem at the stage of notice itself. I hope the company would realise the consumer needs and do the needful to provide proper consumer services so as to maintain its reputation in the market. Please keep a proper record of all the relevant documents; this would be crucial in establishing your claim in the consumer forum. You can file a consumer complaint in the district forum. ■